

I hate the discussions around AI water and electricity use

Posted by u/DigitalHeartbeat729 • • 0 points • 11 comments

I need to scream about this to both pros and antis because I saw yet another post about it and it's making my stomach hurt.

I am a longtime user of chatbots and LLMs. I have tried to quit several times and used to be a member of the subs for recovering from chatbot addiction. My motivation for quitting has always been concerns regarding the water and electricity footprint of them. Every single time.

Some background information: I have... I guess you could say a fixation on environmentalism. I've been vegetarian since elementary school and vegan since around high school. I walk or bike pretty much everywhere because this way I don't contribute to transportation emissions. Before I buy anything online that's not a necessity, I first beat myself up over it for at least several months because what if it gets shipped from far away and lots of resources get used to transport it? Nearly my entire closet is from thrift stores, because then new clothing doesn't need to be manufactured.

And yet it's never enough. Because I like roleplaying on character.ai and sites like that. Occasionally I've wondered if I should just, you know, harm myself. Because I'm clearly not succeeding in my mission. I'm not going to do anything good while existing on the planet, the best I can do is not fuck it up. And I can't even manage that. I've been told multiple times on the quitting chatbots subs that I have self-inflicted guilt, that I need an OCD screening, that I'm not trying to quit for the right reasons... etc. But my thoughts this way keep coming back. And the "ChatGPT drains a small town's worth of water every time you use it" is not helping.

I feel like I'm not sad and self-loathing anymore (most of the time). I'm just angry. Because the people posting this genuinely do not care about the footprint of something when it's not AI. They don't evenly distribute their concerns. They don't post about any other thing that is using energy and resources that isn't AI. It feels disingenuous. Very much disingenuous.

I don't know, just wanted to rant.

Comments

u/Late_Heat_1854 • 1 points • 2025-09-04 15:25 UTC

There's a lot here and I can relate to most of it, but I'm going to address the water/electricity use thing.

I don't know the specific numbers, but the water/electricity usage of AI does tend to be a thought-terminating cliché used as one of the ultimate trump cards for why you shouldn't use AI. Detractors often make the numbers sound ginormous but they're really insignificant in the grand scheme of things, so you shouldn't feel guilty for that reason.

u/Kirbyoto • 2 points • 2025-09-04 14:34 UTC

>My motivation for quitting has always been concerns regarding the water and electricity footprint of them. Every single time.

Imagine someone saying they're trying to quit Youtube or Netflix for this reason. You'd think it was a little strange, right?

u/KrukzGaming • 3 points • 2025-09-04 13:23 UTC

Anti-AI is a trojan horse for anti-nuclear. It's all just anti-progress. "But what about the power usage" YES LETS GET ON BUILDING NUCLEAR PLANTS AND MOVING AWAY FROM FOSSIL FUELS. Clean renewable energy was something humanity was working on anyway, but regressive policies keep hindering this progress. The response to AI consuming energy should be "GET THE OIL BARONS OUT OF POLITICS" not "Oh shit, we'll have to burn more coal"

u/PowderMuse • 2 points • 2025-09-04 09:39 UTC

Sure, data centres use water but we use far more for other things. For example, if you did 20 prompts a day on chatGPT it would take about four years to equal the water consumption to produce a handful of almonds and about 30 years compared to a hamburger.

u/Amethystea • 4 points • 2025-09-04 06:28 UTC

Personal carbon footprints have always been a greenwashing strategy used by big oil to make us blame ourselves and each other while they keep raking in profits hand over dump truck.

<https://www.oxfam.org/en/press-releases/richest-1-emit-much-planet-heating-pollution-two-thirds-humanity>

The wealthiest 1% of the global population is the cause of more pollution than 2/3rds of humanity combined.

[<https://www.theguardian.com/commentisfree/2021/aug/23/big-oil-coined-carbon-footprints-to-blame-us-for-their-greed-keep-them-on-the-hook>]
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Do what you can, but don't think negatively upon yourself if you can't make a difference.. the system is designed that way.

u/Amethystea • 1 points • 2025-09-04 06:31 UTC

I pasted the links out of order.. woops.

u/Tyler_Zoro • 1 points • 2025-09-04 06:00 UTC

> I am a longtime user of chatbots and LLMs. I have tried to quit several times and used to be a member of the subs for recovering from chatbot addiction.

The hell...?!

u/DigitalHeartbeat729 • 4 points • 2025-09-04 06:13 UTC

What are you confused by?

u/Sunbro_413 • 5 points • 2025-09-04 04:44 UTC

So I'm not a therapist, and I don't know what your thoughts are on therapy but that would be my honest first suggestion.

When it comes to environmentalism; the only thing I can really say is that we have made the world too complex. It is next to impossible to do something as simple as buy flowers for your mother without it having an impact on the environment. It is good for you to care about the environment, and I always push to try and recycle ethically and not waste power or water; but you can't blame yourself for the state of things. What I will say is this: Mother Earth is more durable than you realize. Even if we nuked the whole surface; life would eventually recover. That's not an excuse, just a fact.

So there is no real logical reason to feel guilty for spending time on something that makes you happy; that is a privilege we are lucky enough to enjoy by being born in this era.

u/Monstros_Lung • 1 points • 2025-09-04 04:32 UTC

the planet's doomed anyways man just stop caring

lets see how far ai can go

u/theamazingpheonix • 1 points • 2025-09-04 05:59 UTC

really? thats your response? give up? i dont know about you but i live here and i would like to see my world healthy.